

How those spoiled millennials will make the workplace better for everyone

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Have you heard the one about the kid who got his mom to call his boss and ask for a [raise](#)? Or about the college student who quit her summer [internship](#)¹ because it [forbade](#)² Facebook in the office?

Yep, we're talking about Generation Y – [loosely](#)³ defined as those born between 1982 and 1999 – also known as millennials. Perhaps you know them by their other media-generated nicknames: teacup kids, for their supposed emotional [fragility](#)(weakness); boomerang kids, who always [wind](#)⁴ up back home; trophy kids – everyone's a winner; the Peter Pan generation, who'll never grow up.

1. Intern refers to a student who works, sometimes without or with small pay, at an occupation in order to gain work experience. Internship means an official or formal program for beginners in a profession. 前者为实习生，后者为实习，或官方、正式的实习项目；例如大三、大四或研究生们的暑研项目，可以叫做 summer internships.
2. We've learned a lot of verbs related to forbid. We have "[ban](#)," "[forbid](#)," "[prohibit](#)," "[prevent](#)," "[hinder](#)" ...
3. Loosely here means generally, vaguely.
4. 这里是一个固定搭配, wind up. 表示回归。

原句是:

Boomerang kids, who always wind up back home.

Paraphrase:

Boomerang kids often return home after meeting setbacks in the society.

Translation:

归巢族，总是在社会上碰壁之后又返回父母家。

Now this [pampered](#)(spoiled 娇惯的), over-praised, [relentlessly](#)⁵ self-confident generation is flooding the workplace. They'll make up 75 percent of the American workforce by 2025 — and they're trying to change everything.

These are the kids, after all, who text their dads from meetings. They think "business casual" includes skinny jeans. And they expect the company president to listen to their "brilliant idea."⁶

5. Relentless means unstoppable, continued; its synonyms include constantly, without stop, unceasingly;
6. 这里的“brilliant idea”表示 a mild sense of irony, 有一丝嘲讽或调侃之意，即千禧一代自认为自己的想法与众不同。而随着文章的展开，我们从后文中可以看出，作者对这样的“与众不同的想法”是褒奖的。（同学们在今后的写作中，一定要有充分利用“**Punctuation**”这个学术写作策略的意识。任何一篇文章，无论是议论文、说明文、记叙文、描写、学术类写作、留学文书类写作，基本都会灵活而充分地使用 quotation marks, colon, semicolon 等等，尤其是“分号”。而非常可惜的是，很多同学的笔记压根没有记录“分号”的使用规则。）

When will they adapt?

They won't. Ever.⁷ Instead, through their sense of [entitlement](#)⁸ and [inflated](#)(ballooned,

swelled 膨胀的) self-esteem, they'll make the modern workplace adapt to them. And we should thank them for it. Because the modern workplace frankly stinks⁹, and the changes wrought¹⁰ by Gen Y will be good for everybody.

7. Ever here means at any time.

8. Entitlement means the right. 表示权力;

9. Stink means to emit a strong offensive odour.(释放出一股强烈刺鼻的味道) On the basis of the context, the workplace "stinks" means the working condition of the workplace is extremely unpleasant.

10. Wrought is the less used past participle of the verb "work". The changes wrought by Gen Y means the changes made/done/realised by the Gen Y. 该词期末不考查。

The current corporate culture simply doesn't make sense to much of middle-class Gen Y. Since the cradle, these privileged(=entitled 赋予特权的) kids have been offered autonomy(=freedom), control(right to control) and choices. They've been encouraged to show their creativity and to take their extracurricular interests seriously. Raised by parents who wanted to be friends with their kids, they're used to seeing their elders as peers rather than authority figures. When they want something, they're not afraid to say so.

And what the college-educated Gen Y-ers entering the workforce want is engaging¹¹, meaningful, flexible work that doesn't take over¹³ their lives. The grim¹² economy and lack of job opportunities don't seem to be adjusting their expectations downward much, either. According to a recent AP analysis, more than 53 percent of recent college grads are unemployed or underemployed, these numbers don't appear to keep these new grads from thinking their job owes¹⁴ them something.

11. Engaging means attractive.

12. Grim 这个词当下出现的频率越来越高了, 它表示 gloomy, 不景气, 萧条, 惨淡;

13. Take over means to take control or possession of something. 掌控, 掌管;

14. Owe means to be indebted to. For example, you owe me. 你欠我的。所以原句的意思是, 即便找不到工作, 即便找了份低收入工作, 千禧一代的孩子们依旧觉得工作欠了他们。

According to surveys, 50 percent of Gen Y-ers would rather be unemployed than stay in a job they hate. Unlike their child- and mortgage-saddled elders, many can afford to be choosy (= picky) about their jobs, given their notorious(臭名远扬的) reliance(=dependence) on their parents. After all, they can always move back in with Mom and Dad, who are likely to be giving them financial help well into their 20s.

In fact, it's possible that a bad economy can make being choosy even easier – if more people are struggling to find work and living at home, there's no stigma to it.

Despite the recession, or perhaps because of it, corporations are eager to hire and retain(preserve, 表示保留, 留用) the best, most talented Gen Y workers. "In this risky economic environment, the energy, insight and high-tech know-how of Gen Yers will be essential for all high-performing organizations," said a 2009 study on Gen Y from Deloitte, the professional services giant.

Companies are beginning to heed Gen Y's demands. Though flextime and job-sharing have been staples¹⁵ of the workforce for a few decades, they are becoming more accepted, even in

rigid corporate culture, says Laura Schildkraut, a career counselor specializing in¹⁶ the needs of Gen Y. There has also been a rise in new work policies, such as ROWE, or “results only work environment,” a system in which employees are evaluated on their productivity, not the hours they keep. In a ROWE office, the whole team can take off for a 4 p.m. “Spider-Man” showing if they’ve gotten enough done that day.

15. Staple means the most important part. 那么这个句子怎么理解呢？同学们可以将 staple 理解成 necessity: Flextime and job-sharing are two necessary working systems for all the members in the company.

16. Specialise in 表示专门从事某行某业；其意义接近 major in.

Radical-sounding perks¹⁷ such as unlimited paid vacation – assuming (= supposing, 假设) you’ve finished your pressing projects – are more common among companies concerned with attracting and retaining young talent. By 2010, 1 percent of U.S. companies had adopted this previously unheard-of policy, largely in response to the demands of Generation Y.

17. Radical-sounding perks refer to the unheard-of advantageous policies or benefits. 听起来很激进的津贴，其实指的就是闻所未闻的津贴。

The Deloitte study warns that, to retain Gen Y-ers, companies “must foster (= establish, shape, build up) a culture of respect that extends to all employees, regardless of age or level in the organization.” In other words: Treat your Gen Y workers nicely. But we should be treating everyone nicely already, shouldn’t we?

Beyond that, Gen Y’s demands may eventually help bring about the family-friendly policies for which working mothers have been leading the fight. Though the Family and Medical Leave Act of 1993 afforded some protections for working parents, genuine flexibility is still a privilege of the lucky few, and parents who try to leave the office at 5:30 p.m. are often accused of not pulling their weight. Well, guess what? Now everybody wants to leave the office at 5:30. Because they’ve got band practice. Or dinner with their grandma. Or they need to walk their rescue¹⁸ puppy.

18. Although rescue can only be a noun or a verb, here it is used as an adjective. Rescue puppy refers to a dog that is adopted. 领养的（被解救的）宠物狗。

The American workplace has been transformed during upswings and downturns (潮起潮落, ups and downs). The weekend was a product of labor union demands during the relative boom (尤指美国 20 世纪的婴儿潮) of the early 20th century. The Great Depression led to the New Deal’s Fair Labor Standards Act, which introduced the 40-hour workweek and overtime pay to most Americans. But now, workplace change is coming from unadulterated, unorganized worker pushiness¹⁹.

19. Pushy means high-pressure, aggressive. 原句可以转译为：The aggressiveness imposed by Gen Yers has made the workplace change a lot.

So we could continue to roll our eyes at²⁰ Gen Y, accuse them of being spoiled and entitled²¹ and clueless (无厘头的) little brats. We could wish that they’d get taken down a peg by the “school of hard knocks” and learn to accept that this is just the way things are.

But if we’re smart, we’ll cheer them on. Be selfish, Gen Y! Be entitled (= privileged)! Demand what you want. Because we want it, too.

《原生态英语阅读》Unit 3 Passage I
课文与词汇讲解

20. Roll one's eyes. 向上翻白眼，或者咕溜溜地转眼睛，表示不同情绪，如烦躁 impatience, 蔑视 disdain, 恼怒 rage 等;

21. Entitled literally means having a title (字面含义表示拥有一个头衔 title); here it means having the right or privilege to do sth. (它表示某人有特权做某事)